Technological Development, Evolving Themes, and Cultural Expression in Chinese Science Fiction Cinema, 2011-2021

Guo Jinqiu · Chen Yishui

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Abstract

Over the past decade, rapid technological advances and the continuous expansion of the film industry have enabled Chinese science fiction cinema to evolve in production technology, themes and narrative, and cultural expression, as it seeks a development path with distinctive local styles and characteristics. First, from the perspectives of industrial context and technological development, policy-driven industrial upgrading has created favorable conditions for filmmaking, while technological improvements have produced science fiction's most striking visual spectacles. Second, in terms of themes and genres, the wave of online information has guided science fiction filmmaking toward adaptations of fantasy and xuanhuan intellectual properties with distinctive Eastern characteristics, while travel through space and time has also become a popular subject. At the level of cultural expression and underlying values, Chinese science fiction films express the defense of the land, feelings toward the nation, and aspirations toward the structural correspondence between family and nation and a community with a shared future for humanity.

Keywords: science fiction film; Chinese science fiction cinema; genre film; film studies in the new era

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Author information: Guo Jinqiu, Master's student, 2021 cohort, School of Arts and Communication, Beijing Normal University. Chen Yishui, lecturer at the same school and a Zhongying Young Scholar at Beijing Normal University.

Introduction

During 2011-2021, the second decade of the new century, China's film industry expanded continuously, producing numerous large-budget and small- and medium-budget films. Since the promulgation of the Film Industry Promotion Law of the People's Republic of China in 2016, film genres and themes have become increasingly diverse. Within this context, Chinese science fiction filmmaking has changed from the first decade, 2000-2010, chiefly in three respects: industrial support, thematic development, and the cultural expression of its underlying values. Since *The Wandering Earth* (2019), described as inaugurating “year one of Chinese science fiction cinema,” increasing numbers of Chinese filmmakers have deliberately incorporated science fiction elements into films of different genres and subjects. Gradually moving beyond the first decade's almost mythic fascination with technological aesthetics, they have sought an aesthetic and cultural path with distinctive local characteristics.

I. The Industrial Context and Technological Development of Chinese Science Fiction Cinema

Since 2010, improvements in state policy and support, together with scientific and technological advances, have made the film industry's continuing rise an inevitable trend. The Chinese film market of the 2010s developed new features, chiefly "segmentation, community differentiation, and integration into everyday life."[1, pp. 39-44] Against this background, Chinese science fiction cinema has moved from dormancy toward awakening. The emergence of outstanding films such as *The Wandering Earth* and *Crazy Alien* in 2019 brought new hope to domestic science fiction filmmaking, which had been somewhat disoriented by its reliance on Hollywood's technological aesthetics. Science fiction consequently became a prominent social topic and a new wave in media culture.

1. Industrial Upgrading Opens New Development Paths

The rise of Chinese science fiction filmmaking in the 2010s resulted from the influence and support of multiple aspects of Chinese society.

First, it benefited from the film industry's flourishing over the past decade. From the release of the draft Film Industry Promotion Law for public consultation in 2011 to its formal passage and implementation in 2016, policies reforming the film market became decisive factors in its steady development. They advanced the transition from cinema as a public cultural undertaking to cinema as an industry, laying a firm foundation for standardized development. Flexible government regulation and support also provided important guarantees for genre diversification in the 2010s.

Second, beyond the top-down "visible hand," the market's "invisible hand" played an indispensable role. Advances in internet technologies improved production standards while accelerating the entry of internet capital into cinema. Under the consumer-to-business (C2B) model of the "Internet Plus" era, traditional film and television companies began seeking new development paths, changing conventional theatrical marketing and turning toward online media to integrate resources. In 2014, for example, Enlight Media and Qihoo 360 established a joint venture and a paid video website to expand content resources. In 2019, Huayi Brothers and Alibaba Pictures signed a strategic cooperation agreement to share audiovisual resources and distribution channels. "The internet's greatest changes to traditional cinema occur chiefly in industrial operations such as marketing, distribution, exhibition, and the development of derivative products. It helps cinema enter a new stage in marketing, user relations, back-end services, and copyright."[2, pp. 6-10] As traditional production companies collaborate with internet-platform capital, IP development, games, literature, and other entertainment resources are being integrated into large digital entertainment value chains, continually opening new routes for the film industry.

Third, the prosperity of China's film industry provides fertile ground for domestic science fiction, whose rise also derives from audiences' pursuit of visual spectacle. Amid an emphasis on technological and cultural confidence, the influx of foreign science fiction films and the popularity of domestic science fiction literature have significantly increased young Chinese audiences' expectations and imaginative investment in domestic productions. The spectacular nature of science fiction also helps determine its market appeal. Responding to this demand, a localized Chinese model of "high-concept" science fiction production has gradually become mainstream. As a milestone, *The Wandering Earth* presents spectacles with a distinctly Chinese aesthetic, including desolate yet magnificent frozen Chinese buildings and cyberpunk underground cities. Such scenes satisfy Chinese audiences' expectations while demonstrating the strength of China's film-industrial technologies.

2. Technological Advances Produce Visual Spectacle

Visual effects, a primary component of science fiction's aesthetic experience, depend on computer-generated effects technologies. In developing production technologies, China has kept pace with international hardware advances and continually refined its own effects through adoption, learning, and innovation. In this respect, *The Wandering Earth* demonstrates considerable technical achievement. As a "catalyst" of science fiction filmmaking, effects both construct screen images and possess artistic value, principally in three areas: practical effects; three-dimensional effects and characterization; and digital matte painting and spatial construction.

First, practical effects impose high requirements for the craftsmanship, appearance, and usability of props. Every step, from hand-drawn designs and three-dimensional software modeling to the production of physical props and their appearance on screen, challenges effects teams. Whereas traditional visual spectacle depends mainly on creative costume, makeup, and prop work, science fiction teams often require expertise in animation and film, industrial design, and specialist fields related to the subject. Practical effects props must be considered across design, fabrication, and on-set shooting. *Space Dream* (2011), for example, extensively depicts China's future space station. Specialists in mechanical physics, electronics and chemical engineering, and digital art jointly produced a 1:8 scale effects model of the station. The integration of such a large, precise physical model with digital effects broke new ground in Chinese filmmaking. *The Wandering Earth* likewise required practical effects design for extensive costumes, weapons, and cockpit environments. Its creators explain: "Every part that looks detachable can actually be detached. We did not make it as a single molded unit. This maximizes realism for audiences: each component appears to have a genuine function, and it is also convenient to paint and assemble."[3, pp. 32-50] To create a convincing aesthetic of spectacle on the big screen, filmmakers therefore consider the aesthetic effects of shooting and postproduction rendering from the initial industrial-design stage.

Second, three-dimensional computer-generated effects are widely used in science fiction and are indispensable in both setting construction and characterization. They can reconstruct history, reproduce reality, and create virtual worlds. Everything from buildings, transport, galaxies, and the universe to costume patterns and metallic materials requires effects that bring the medium's material properties together with human science-fictional imagination. In *The Wandering Earth*, more than 60 percent of costumes and props combined physical fabrication and digital technologies. Settings also used dynamic three-dimensional imagery, such as the exploding space station and engine flames, producing immersion and intense impact. Three-dimensional effects also render imagined scenes and virtual characters while conveying interior emotions and deeper feelings. In *A Writer's Odyssey* (2021), Redmane, who battles the protagonist Guan Ning and his daughter, is entirely generated through CG modeling and motion capture. The team spent three years refining every pore and muscle to produce a realistic, spectacular, and intimidating figure. The character's success highlights paternal love and completes the author's metaphor of resistance to evil corporate organizations and the power of capital. Three-dimensional effects thus enhance spectacle while enriching detail and giving characters greater dimensionality.

Third, digital matte painting and spatial construction create convincing, immersive cinematic images. Matte painting commonly depicts settings that do not exist or would be difficult to build, combining artists' manual painting with computer-based postproduction. To present Shanghai's frozen, post-apocalyptic condition, *The Wandering Earth*'s team created more than 200 effects paintings of the city, subsequently refining them digitally. Each shot was meticulously designed, including particle simulations of blizzards, to complete the settings and deepen thematic expression. More than 8,000 storyboard panels and 10,000 props also contributed to the space station, ice fields, and planetary engines, with over 30 minutes of animated previsualization enabling a precise realization of the source work. The combination of spatial

description and artistic impact gives audiences a rich sensory experience.

II. Thematic Creation and Genre Evolution in Chinese Science Fiction Cinema

Science fiction, as an important film genre, continually reflects a country's level of cinematic development. Chinese science fiction filmmaking has broadly passed through an embryonic stage (before 1980), an exploratory stage (1981-2000), and a development stage (2000 to the present), producing many outstanding works. Its rapid development over the past decade derives from technological progress and from filmmakers' deliberate exploration of innovative expression from Chinese perspectives. Alongside established science fiction elements, they incorporate fantasy, xuanhuan, and time travel, increasing spectacle and adding mystery and romance.

1. Fantasy, Xuanhuan, and IP-Based Creation

As a genre concept, “fantasy” is understood here as a film genre emerging after the beginning of the new century. Initially, Chinese film circles translated Hollywood fantasy as mohuan, a term drawing on the “magical realism” of mid-twentieth-century Latin American literature, which uses ancient mythic thinking to describe local national-cultural characteristics. Peter Jackson's *The Lord of the Rings* (2001) marked the new-century emergence of fantasy cinema.[4, pp. 156-158] Films such as *Harry Potter* and *The Chronicles of Narnia* followed, inaugurating a new wave of fantasy production. Hollywood fantasy's global popularity also encouraged Chinese cinema's efforts to seek and establish cultural identity within globalization.

Many Chinese science fiction films of the past decade exhibit genre hybridity, combining “science fiction + fantasy” or “science fiction + xuanhuan.” In his early study published in Chinese as A History of World Science Fiction Cinema, Christian Hellmann identifies eight principal categories: utopia or dystopia; space adventure; monsters and supernatural creatures; alien invasions threatening Earth; robots; time travel; disaster films; and alternative or parallel worlds. Not every subject suits the Chinese market, but the incorporation of fantasy and xuanhuan continually expands science fiction's narrative boundaries, expressing local cultural and social reflections through “soft science fiction.” *The Soul* (2021), for example, combines science fiction and fantasy to explore family ethics, morality, and human nature through encounters between humanity and self-interest, life and consciousness, science and metaphysics. Its supernatural opening, centered on “soul transfer,” captures attention before moving toward future technologies such as genetic repair. Ultimately, it exposes the proliferating evil desires behind powerful interest groups' immense wealth and their anxieties about death and the loss of power. Soft science fiction and fantasy act as narrative vehicles that enrich sensory experience and deepen thematic understanding.

Extending beyond fantasy, xuanhuan is more deeply rooted in traditional Chinese culture. Initially carried by online literature and appearing extensively on literary websites around 2005, its most distinctive characteristic is “going to every possible length to invoke spirits and the supernatural.”[5, pp. 25-39] Its stories chiefly occur in imagined worlds of magic and Daoist arts. It gradually became a relatively recognized literary category, and IP based on xuanhuan novels subsequently spread from literature and comics into audiovisual adaptations for film, television, and games.

Several factors have driven the recent popularity of xuanhuan adaptations. First, young people exposed to the internet from an early age have made xuanhuan a major vehicle of youth subculture. Online media, together with highly engaged and creative fan communities, have inevitably increased these properties' value. Science fiction and fantasy offer subcultural communities virtual spaces of imaginative fiction. The Daomu Biji franchise, for instance, began with Nanpai Sanshu's novel of tomb exploration and was adapted into a web series and games. Fans also created artistically valuable fiction and comics about characters such as Zhang Qiling and Wu Xie. Its fantasy-adventure film adaptation, *Time Raiders*, opened

in China in 2016. Similar works include *Chronicles of the Ghostly Tribe* (2015) and *The Thousand Faces of Dunjia* (2017). Their effects and technologically inflected mechanical props demonstrate the industrial standards of Chinese cinematic technological aesthetics in the second decade of the century and contain certain science fiction elements. Yet adaptation teams' shortcomings in respecting source works, reconstructing settings, guiding values, and balancing artistry and authenticity cannot be ignored. Excessive reliance on traffic-driving stars also damages overall aesthetics. Artistic quality and cultural expression therefore remain problematic.

2. Travel through Space and Time

The past decade has also produced numerous Chinese science fiction films involving time travel, including *Timeless Love* (2013), *20 Once Again* (2015), and *How Long Will I Love U* (2018). “Travel through space and time” means that a character's body or consciousness returns to the past or moves into the future along a timeline. In such films, story time and filmic space are altered and interwoven to drive the plot.

In structuralist critic Gérard Genette's theory of narrative time, “order” concerns the relationship between the arrangement of events or temporal segments in narrative discourse and their chronological succession in the story.[6, p. 14] Film narratologist François Jost summarizes this as comparing the sequence of events in the fictional world with the order in which they appear in the narrative.[7, p. 140] Discrepancies between story order and narrative order produce temporal disorder, or “anachrony.” “Changing the future” and “making amends for the past” consequently become common plot patterns. Protagonists often return to the past to prevent humanity's apocalyptic destruction or repair shortcomings in their personal lives, changing reality and thereby the future. In Reset, for example, Xia Tian, a single mother working at a physics institute, invents a particle technology enabling time travel to save her son, brutally killed by the villain. Versions of herself from different times return to the past to battle evil and ultimately rescue him. The science fiction comedy *My Girlfriend Is a Robot* (2020) tells of an elderly protagonist who invents a robot resembling a girl he met when young and sends it into the past to save his younger self from an accident.

Many journeys through time seek to compensate for past regrets rather than merely change the future. The time-travel fantasy comedy *Hi, Mom*, for example, tells of daughter Jia Xiaoling and mother Li Huanying returning to the 1980s after an accident. Jia travels bodily, while Li's consciousness inhabits her younger self. They comfort and understand one another. Jia, who has never excelled, strives to “make her mother happy,” while her mother uses the final opportunity to express her wish that her daughter grow up healthy. They make amends and redeem one another. Through thematic metaphor, time-travel films reflect on time and life, recurrence and choice, and technology and ethics.

In characterization, protagonists from earlier or later periods possess different information and knowledge. Their “stranger” status grants them foreknowledge, making them readily cast as adventurous heroes. The science fiction comedy *Ultra Reinforcement* (2012), for example, follows an unsuccessful man who returns to the Tang dynasty with the help of a jade pendant. Using modern knowledge and technology, he restores altered history and becomes a hero. In *How Long Will I Love U*, Lu Ming from 1999 and Gu Xiaojiao from 2018 meet and fall in love in an apartment where their times intersect. To protect her, Lu returns to the past, prevents himself from turning to evil, and saves her father. Characters in time-travel films possess the power to change their own fate and even humanity's, giving them a strongly heroic quality.

Although time travel is a relatively localized and innovative subject in Chinese science fiction of the second decade, and its screenwriting, aesthetics, and cultural expression show greater maturity than in the first, it must avoid several common structural flaws. The “temporal paradox”[A] is a frequent problem: current films rarely develop rigorous dramatic logic, often leaving time travel at the level of premise or background. Like other science fiction subjects, it must also consider limits to audience comprehension.

Balancing sophisticated story design and informational complexity with viewers' understanding and enjoyment imposes considerable demands on narrative skills, cinematic language, and temporal arrangement.

3. The Genre's Maturation and Difficulties

Since the beginning of the century, Chinese science fiction has generated a new wave of technological aesthetics through experiments in combining genres and subjects. Only with *The Wandering Earth* in 2019 was its "year one" finally proclaimed. From the standpoint of filmmaking, outstanding science fiction depends on narrative logic and cultural expression as much as spectacle. Domestic productions should clearly distinguish and appropriately balance primary and secondary genre elements. These can be established through five aspects: theme, plot, narrative structure, characterization, and visual style.

The Wandering Earth's pioneering significance thus lies in combining powerful effects and a strong screenplay with a balanced distribution of elements: science fiction expressing technological aesthetics and scientific imagination, alongside the attachment to family and nation advocated by traditional Chinese culture. This integration of art and industry produced an exemplary science fiction film. *Crazy Alien*, released in the same year, tells an absurd story of an alien's visit to Earth through a more complete narrative structure and effects spectacle. Continuing director Ning Hao's "crazy comedy" style, it ultimately "radically dismantles and adapts Liu Cixin's hard-core science fiction story 'The Village Teacher,' achieving a 'perfect' localized creation of Chinese science fiction cinema."[8, p. 108]

Shanghai Fortress, also released in 2019, by contrast, uses science fiction as an outer shell while its narrative logic remains confused. Despite a future setting, its scenes and plot fail to convey futurity. Instead, extensive attention to the romantic relationship between its leads reverses the priorities, produces structural confusion, and weakens genre integration. Its screenplay also suffers from imbalances in characterization and emotional logic. Some characters are flat and unconvincing. Jiang Yang, for example, wears long bangs despite being a soldier, and his uniform and cap do not conform to customary practice. The lack of dimensional, convincing characterization also makes behavior and personality implausible.

Although this film's artistic achievement falls markedly below the other two released in "year one," it exposes problems shared by films combining xuanhuan, time travel, and other genres and subjects. Chinese science fiction in the first two decades of the century has therefore made a qualitative leap, but still urgently requires a sustained accumulation of high-quality productions in sufficient quantity to open a genuinely new era.

III. The Underlying Values and Cultural Expression of Chinese Science Fiction Cinema

As a distinctive genre, science fiction conveys not only technological imaginings of the future and extraterrestrial worlds but also a nation's cultural and spiritual core. Hollywood's classic *Star Wars* series, for example, pioneered the successful integration of CGI into science fiction narrative. More importantly, it clearly depicts competing forces conducting colonial conquests on other planets. Such cultural expression matters because the American science fiction themes of territorial expansion and cosmic conquest derive from the cultural core of a white-dominated imperial-colonial system. Chinese science fiction must therefore, both necessarily and appropriately, express fundamentally different cultural conceptions from Western science fiction dominated by Hollywood.

1. A Land-Based Spatial Outlook: Guarding the Earth

The spatial conceptions of Chinese science fiction reflect a cultural logic of geographical identity developed over thousands of years. Unlike American films such as the *Star Trek* series and *Interstellar*, which leave Earth for colonial expansion and adventure in outer space, Chinese science fiction tends to position humanity as the guardian of Earth rather than an extraterrestrial colonizer. In *Chronicles of the Ghostly Tribe* (2015), aliens hide in caves deep beneath Earth and even identify themselves as a local Chinese ethnic minority, displaying pronounced human characteristics. In Stephen Chow's *CJ7* (2008) and *The Mermaid* (2016), an extraterrestrial dog decides to remain on Earth with the protagonist, while mermaids live as mysterious creatures in the deep sea. At different levels, these films express peaceful coexistence between humans and animals, different peoples, or humanity and marine nature.

The Wandering Earth provides the first clear presentation of a distinctive Chinese spatial conception of science fiction, demonstrating narratively the possibility of an Earth-centered spatial model wholly different from Hollywood space opera. Facing Earth's destruction, Chinese heroes insist on “taking the Earth with us” to preserve their planetary home. Hard-science-fiction technologies such as ion propulsion draw Earth through the universe toward a stellar environment suitable for its survival. This expresses, through science fiction's imagination, a cultural position of “the unity of humanity and nature,” the central cultural logic behind its successful inauguration of “year one.” The creators consistently situate humanity within an organic system of harmonious spatial coexistence with Earth, emphasizing the communal characteristics of human civilization.

The film thus explicitly articulates an understanding of human civilization guided by a Chinese science fiction outlook. Liu Peiqiang's memorable line, “A civilization without human beings is not human civilization,” rejects a purely biological conception of humanity associated with Western Darwinian evolution. It locates human identity within an organic system of social civilization, showing that Chinese science fiction focuses the meaning and function of advanced technology on safeguarding Earth and sustaining humanity's civilized social order.

2. National Sentiments and Mission

Nostalgia is common in Chinese science fiction. Connected with the ancient Greek nostos, “returning home,” nostalgia denotes homesickness and a bittersweet longing for past things, people, or environments.[9, pp. 61-64] As China's globalization deepens, modern social orders gradually disrupt the traditional ideal of a small state with few inhabitants. Generations leave their native places for other regions or countries to survive or pursue better opportunities. Intensifying nostalgia becomes part of Chinese science fiction's emotional construction, often through characters' longing for home and relatives. In *Future X-Cops* (2010), Zhou Zhihao travels from 2080 to 2020 on a mission. Although he finds love in 2020, he chooses to return to 2080, where he was born and raised, to defend his home. In *Shanghai Fortress*, even when Shanghai is Earth's last surviving territory, people remain to resist extraterrestrial forces to the end. This expresses nostalgia and the geographical identity of guardians of humanity's home.

Under the guidance of the “Four Confidences,” China's science and technology have advanced rapidly, its overall national strength has grown, and its cinema's international standing has risen. Emotional expression in Chinese science fiction has consequently shifted from fear, tentative engagement, and anxiety toward modern technology to the confidence and responsibility of the world's second-largest economy. In *The Wandering Earth*, Chinese inhabitants of underground cities still celebrate the Spring Festival with dragon and lion dances. *Crazy Alien* uses monkeys to depict the endangered art of performing-monkey shows, reflecting on the loss of Chinese culture. The presentation of Chinese elements and cultural confidence in outstanding works embodies Chinese filmmakers' important mission and the accumulated transmission of

thousands of years of Chinese culture.

3. Expressing the Structural Correspondence between Family and Nation

As an important vehicle for patriotic feeling, cinema often constructs narratives of family-nation correspondence through characterization and dramatic logic, moving from individual households to attachment to family and nation. Chinese science fiction frequently uses its techniques and creative ideas to express this relationship. *The Wandering Earth*'s adaptation, for example, concretizes the source's themes of generations and home through father-son and familial relationships. This cultural image embodies Confucian identification with family ethics and the coexistence of science fiction and traditional values. In *My Country, My Parents*, whose central narrative pattern is fatherhood, the science fiction episode "Go Youth" follows Xiaoxiao, a boy dreaming of science, who unexpectedly forms a temporary father-son relationship with Jing Yihao, a robot from the future. Influenced by his robotic father, Xiaoxiao courageously pursues his scientific aspirations. The spirit of technological innovation and the dream of national rejuvenation are transmitted between them.

As a social proposition rooted in Chinese culture, family-nation correspondence extends beyond reproducing father-son narratives. Numerous films reflect the larger nation through a small household. *Hi, Mom* uses time travel to reconstruct the historical setting and spirit of the 1980s. A large slogan on Shengli Chemical Factory's wall reads, "Time is life; efficiency is money," presenting China's rapid industrial development and advance toward modernization. Li Huanying is both a devoted mother working tirelessly for her daughter and family and a generational image of Chinese workers contributing their youth to national construction. As a black-and-white television in the film announces: "Those born in the 1950s and 1960s became the mainstay of this era's workforce. They stepped lightly, their faces filled with the smiles of the age." These family-nation narratives bring a distinctively Chinese humanistic spirit and emotional culture to science fiction.

4. A Global Outlook: A Community with a Shared Future for Humanity

Many Chinese science fiction films of the past decade construct a community with a shared future for humanity, most successfully exemplified by *The Wandering Earth*.

First, narratively, Liu Qi takes his sister and commandeers a transport vehicle, joining people worldwide in successive efforts at global rescue. Liu Peiqiang sacrifices himself by driving the space station toward Jupiter. Although these heroic acts of planetary salvation are individual, they ultimately rise from household ethics to the higher dimension of humanity's shared future. In the tension between a "new home" and an "old home," the film rejects colonial expansion toward other worlds, as found in Hollywood, and steadfastly preserves humanity's existing planetary home. This conception derives from traditional Chinese agrarian culture's respect for and protection of native land. Unlike the territorial outlook of ancient dynasties, the formerly China-centered geographical conception of "Greater China" gradually becomes, within new-century globalization, a worldview of peaceful development and joint progress with other peoples and nations, crystallizing in the decade under discussion into the ultimate concern for a shared human future.

Second, audiovisual language mobilizes imagery and sound to construct this community. In the long take when Han Duoduo first leaves the underground city and looks out through the vehicle window, the camera moves from near to far, from the transport vehicle to the Navigator space station's viewpoint. Within one minute it expands from local vehicles and mines to the spectacle of the frozen Earth and innumerable planetary engines. Besides establishing the world and delivering visual impact, it communicates a grand conception of humanity's common home at the apocalypse. Sound likewise supports this conception. On the Navigator station, Liu Peiqiang tells the Russian astronaut Makarov, "We still have to take the children

to Lake Baikal to fish for salmon," while Makarov replies, "We'd be better off having Chongqing hotpot." Such dialogue conveys more than harmony and solidarity among astronauts from different countries: it affirms one another's cultural traditions and human landscapes and their shared wish to save Earth, expressing the aspiration to build a community with a shared future for humanity.

IV. Conclusion

Chinese science fiction filmmaking in the second decade of the century underwent a remarkable qualitative transformation in effects technology, industrial scale, localized combinations of genres and subjects, narrative strategies, and cultural expression. Especially since the prominent inauguration of "year one" in 2019, increasing numbers of productions have consciously incorporated science fiction elements and explored localized creative methods and paths. The technological elements in science fiction should serve not merely to display advanced effects and spectacular aesthetics, but the cultural logic of narrative expression: how to tell a story about a future civilizational order. Science fiction is, to some extent, a cultural allegory addressing major themes. Its further development therefore depends on the technological logics and cultural positions contemporary Chinese filmmakers adopt to express cultural-political allegories from Chinese perspectives and offer, through cross-cultural circulation, an alternative to Hollywood's dominant production path.

Notes and References

The original's numbered references and cited page numbers are retained. Quotations are translated from the supplied Chinese article. The references below preserve the Chinese editions cited by the authors; English titles of Chinese-language articles are descriptive translations.

{A} The “temporal paradox,” also called the “grandmother paradox” in the source, concerns a person who travels into the past and kills their own grandmother, thereby causing their own disappearance. On this reasoning, an ancestor cannot be killed by a descendant traveling back through time.

[1] Li Xuan. “The Cultural Landscape and Aesthetic Consciousness of Chinese Cinema since the Beginning of the Twenty-First Century.” China Film Market, 2020, no. 6.

[2] Rao Shuguang and Xian Jia. “‘Internet Plus’ and the Advancement of China's Film Landscape.” Contemporary Cinema, 2015, no. 7.

[3] Li Jie and Li Ye. “Practical Effects: The Hard Core of Science Fiction Cinema - Visiting the Industrial Design Team behind *The Wandering Earth*.” Design, 2019, no. 6.

[4] Chen Yishui. “Cultural Imagination in Geographical Spectacle: Comparing Fantasy Films in Hollywood and Chinese-Language Cinema.” Contemporary Cinema, 2013, no. 8.

[5] Tao Dongfeng. “Youth Literature, Xuanhuan Literature, and Tomb-Raiding Literature: An Overview of Post-1980s Writing.” Journal of China University of Political Science and Law, 2008, no. 5.

[6] Gérard Genette. *Narrative Discourse / Narrative Discourse Revisited*. Translated into Chinese by Wang Wenrong. Beijing: China Social Sciences Press, 1990. Combined Chinese edition.

[7] André Gaudreault and François Jost. What Is Film Narratology? [Chinese edition of *Le récit cinématographique*]. Translated by Liu Yunzhou. Beijing: The Commercial Press, 2005.

[8] Wang Yunshu. “Comedy-Genre Narrative Strategies and Cultural Expression in *Crazy Alien*.” New Films, 2019, no. 2.

[9] Wang Yichuan. “Chinese-Style Nostalgia in a Global Context.” Contemporary Cinema, 2004, no. 2.

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Terminology and Translation Notes

“Practical effects” renders physical effects made through props, models, and fabrication; “CGI,” “motion capture,” “digital matte painting,” and “previsualization” use established production terminology. “Story time,” “narrative order,” and “anachrony” follow narratological usage associated with Gérard Genette, André Gaudreault, and François Jost. Xuanhuan is retained for the culturally specific Chinese fantasy category and distinguished from the broader term “fantasy.” “Family-nation correspondence” renders the structural analogy between household and nation; “a community with a shared future for humanity” consistently renders the article's concluding political-cultural concept.

Film titles use established English release or catalog titles where identifiable. *My Girlfriend Is a Robot* is a literal rendering of the title of the 2020 film, also circulated as My Robot Girlfriend and Yes, I Do! The source's “grandmother paradox” is retained in its note rather than silently replaced by the more familiar “grandfather paradox.” Apparent chronological slips referring to the century's “last decade” have been rendered according to the article's stated 2011-2021 scope. Other interpretive and historical claims remain the authors' arguments.

Names and work titles were checked against Cornell University Press's record for Genette's Narrative Discourse (https://cornellpress.cornell.edu/book/9780801492594/narrative-discourse/) and the publisher's record for Gaudreault and Jost's *Le récit cinématographique* (https://www.hachette.fr/livre/le-recit-cinematographique-3e-ed-films-et-series-televisees-9782200614492/). *The Soul*'s English release title was checked against its official Netflix listing (https://www.netflix.com/gb/title/81415286). The translation does not substitute newly sourced page numbers for those of the Chinese editions cited in the original.